UNIT 5

Songs of the Self

- Beloved Boles
- Préférence Nationale
- Mirror (Poem)

Beloved Boles

COMPREHENSION 1

When I was a student at Moscow, I happened to live alongside a Polish woman, Teresa by name. She was tall and strong, with bushy black eyebrows, dark brown hair and a large coarse face. The gleam of her dark eyes, her thick bass* voice, and her muscular vigour, horrified me. I lived on the top floor and her room was opposite mine.

I never left my door open when I knew her to be at home. Sometimes I chanced to meet her on the staircase or in the yard, and she would smile at me. Occasionally, I saw her drunk, with bleary eyes, and tousled hair. On such occasions she would speak to me.

1. Based on the narrator's description, what specific physical traits of Teresa contribute to his feeling of horror?

2. Why does the narrator likely keep his door closed whenever he knows Teresa is at home?

3. In the context of the passage, what does the phrase "muscular vigour" suggest about how the narrator perceives Teresa's femininity?

4. What do the details about the "top floor," "staircase," and "yard" tell the reader about the living conditions and social environment of the characters?

5. What is the primary tone of the narrator toward Teresa in this excerpt?

- A) Compassionate and curious
- B) Intimidated and judgmental
- C) Indifferent and bored
- D) Affectionate and protective

ANSWERS

1. Her bushy eyebrows, coarse face, thick bass voice, and muscular strength.

2. He feels physically intimidated and uncomfortable by her presence; he views her as a threat or a "horrifying" figure.

3. It suggests he finds her strength unfeminine or overwhelming, contrasting with the social expectations of women at the time.

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4. It suggests a crowded, modest, or perhaps impoverished urban tenement where residents live in close, unavoidable proximity.

5 B Intimidated and judgmental

COMPREHENSION 2

A week or two passed. It was evening. I was sitting at my window. I was bored; the weather was dirty. I didn't want to go out. Then the door opened. Heaven be praised! Someone came in.

"Oh, Mr Student, you have no pressing business, I hope?"

It was Teresa. Humph!

"No. What is it?"

"I was going to ask you, sir, to write me another letter."

"Very well! To Boles, eh?"

"No, this time it is from him."

"Wha-at?"

"Stupid that I am! It is not for me, Mr Student, I beg your pardon. It is for a friend of mine, that is to say, not a Friend but an acquaintance a man. He has a sweetheart just like me here, another Teresa. That's how it is. Will you, sir, write a letter to this Teresa?"

I looked at her. Her face was troubled, her fingers were trembling. I was a bit fogged at first and then I guessed how it was.

"Look here, my lady," I said, "there are no Boleses or Teresas at all, and you've been telling me a pack of lies. Don't you come fooling around me any longer. I have no wish to be your friend or acquaintance, or your 'young man.' Do you understand?"

And suddenly she grew strangely terrified and distraught. She began to shift from foot to foot without moving from the place, and spluttered comically, as if she wanted to say something and couldn't. I waited to see what would come of all this. And somehow, I began to think that I had misjudged her a little. It was evidently something very different.

QUESTIONS

1. At the beginning of the passage, why does the narrator initially welcome the interruption ("Heaven be praised!"), and how does his mood change when he realizes who it is?

2. Teresa asks the narrator to write a letter *to* herself *from* a fictional person (Boles). What does this request reveal about her emotional state and her life in Moscow?

3. Why does the narrator react so harshly at first, calling her stories a "pack of lies" and telling her not to "fool around"?

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4. Which of the following best describes the narrator’s "epiphany" at the end of the passage?

- A) He realizes Teresa is trying to steal from him.
- B) He understands that Teresa is actually in a dangerous relationship.
- C) He senses that her lies are a desperate attempt to cope with loneliness.
- D) He decides that he is genuinely in love with Teresa.

5. Which of the following descriptions are used by the narrator to justify his feeling of "horror" toward Teresa?

A. Her thick bass voice and muscular vigour.

B. Her habit of leaving her door open to watch him.

C. Her large coarse face and bushy black eyebrows.

D. Her appearance when drunk, with bleary eyes and tousled hair.

Choose the correct option from the following:

i) A, B, and C

ii) A, C, and D

iii) B and D only

iv) A and C only

ANSWERS

1. He was bored and disliked the "dirty" weather, so he wanted company; however, his "Humph!" indicates he was disappointed or annoyed that the visitor was Teresa.

2. It reveals she is profoundly lonely and is inventing a romance to provide herself with the affection and connection she lacks in reality.

3. He feels his intelligence is being insulted by her obvious fabrications and he wants to maintain a social distance from someone he considers "coarse."

4. C) He senses that her lies are a desperate attempt to cope with loneliness.

5. ii) A, C, and D

COMPREHENSION 3

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I understood at last. And I felt so sick, so miserable, so ashamed, somehow. Alongside of me, not three yards away, lived a human creature who had nobody in the world to treat her kindly. With no one to be affectionate to her, this human being had invented a friend for herself!

“Look, now! you wrote me a letter to Boles, and I gave it to someone else to read it to me; and when they read it to me, I listened and fancied that Boles was there. And I asked you to write me a letter from Boles to Teresa–that is to me. When they write such a letter for me, and read it to me, I feel quite sure that Boles is there. And life grows easier for me.”

“Take you for a blockhead!” said I to myself when I heard this.

And thenceforth, regularly, twice a week, I wrote a letter to Boles, and an answer from Boles to Teresa. She, of course, listened to them, and wept like anything. She roared, I should say, with her bass voice. And in return for my service, she began to mend the holes I had in my socks, shirts, and other articles of clothing. Three months later she was thrown into prison for some reason or the other and by now she must surely be dead.

1. Why was it necessary for Teresa to have the narrator write a letter *from* Boles and then have someone else read it to her?

2. The narrator describes Teresa "roaring" with her "bass voice" as she weeps. How has the meaning of this "bass voice" changed from the beginning of the story to this moment?

3. What does the fact that Teresa was "thrown into prison for some reason or the other" suggest about her life and status in society?

4. What was the primary reason the narrator felt "ashamed" after hearing Teresa's explanation?

- A) He realized he had been charging her too much for the letters.
- B) He felt guilty for mocking a woman who was only trying to escape her extreme loneliness.
- C) He was embarrassed that he didn't know how to mend his own clothes.
- D) He was afraid that Teresa would be thrown into prison because of his letters.

5. Which of the following statements best reflects the "humanity" the narrator finally recognizes in Teresa?

A. She was a skilled seamstress who mended his clothes for free.

B. She possessed a powerful imagination that allowed her to create a source of love where none existed.

C. She was physically stronger than the other students in Moscow.

D. She admitted that she was a "blockhead" for lying about Boles.

Choose the correct option from the following:

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i) A and C

ii) B only

iii) B and D

Iv) A and B only

ANSWERS

1.Hearing the letter read aloud by another person made the fantasy feel objective and real, allowing her to truly believe "Boles was there."

2. At first, it was a source of fear and "horror" for the narrator; by the end, it becomes a symbol of her raw, unfiltered human suffering.

3. It shows she was a marginalized person with no social protection or importance, whose disappearance from society was treated as a minor, vague event.

4 . B He felt guilty for mocking a woman who was only trying to escape her extreme loneliness.

5. ii) B only

DISCOURSES

WRITE UP

In the story "BELOVED BOLES," Maxim Gorky explores how prejudice and social barriers can prevent us from seeing the "human creature" in others. Prepare a write up discussing the above said theme and the transformation of the narrator's attitude toward Teresa.

(Hints:- narrator's initial fear and disgust – Teresa's "horrifying" physical appearance – social status and dehumanization – the discovery of the "Boles" secret – imagination as a survival mechanism – coping with absolute isolation – shift from arrogance to shame – the "blockhead" realization – lack of compassion vs. intellectual superiority – evolution of mutual support – mending clothes and writing letters – tragic ending and imprisonment – indifference of society – reflection on marginalized "human creatures")

The Transformation of Empathy

The story "Beloved Boles " by Maxim Gorky is a powerful exploration of human loneliness and the shift from prejudice to empathy. Initially, the narrator views his neighbor, Teresa, through a lens of fear

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and disgust. He describes her "muscular vigour" and "bass voice" as something "horrifying," treating her more like an animal than a woman. This **dehumanization** stems from his social status as a student looking down upon a "coarse" person.

However, the turning point occurs when the narrator discovers Teresa's secret: she has invented a fictional lover named Boles. He realizes that her "lies" are actually a desperate **survival mechanism** to cope with absolute isolation. By writing letters to and from a non-existent person, Teresa creates a world where she is loved.

Upon realizing this, the narrator's arrogance turns to **shame**. He calls himself a "blockhead," recognizing that his intellectual superiority was meaningless because he lacked basic compassion. The relationship evolves into one of mutual support—he provides her with emotional hope through his writing, while she cares for him by mending his clothes. The tragic ending, where Teresa disappears into the prison system, highlights the indifference of society toward the "human creatures" who live on its margins.

DIARY

'Mr Student' was taken aback when he realised that both 'Boles' and 'the relationship of Boles and Teresa' were imaginary. He realises that there are individuals who struggle to establish an identity of their own. Draft the possible diary entry by 'Mr Student' that day.

26 JANUARY

MONDAY

I feel like a complete blockhead tonight. For weeks, I have lived across from Teresa, judging her by her coarse face and her bass voice, treating her as something "horrifying" rather than human. I thought my status as a student made me superior, but today I realized how blind I have been.

When she asked me to write that letter—the one *from* Boles to herself—I initially mocked her for her "pack of lies." But then I saw her fingers trembling. I saw the distraught look in her eyes. It hit me like a physical blow: Boles isn't real. He is a ghost she created because the real world has given her no one to love.

How desperate must a soul be to invent a life just to make the day bearable? While I sit here with my books and my "pressing business," she sits three yards away, struggling to establish even a shred of identity in a city that treats her like an animal. I am sick with shame for my own coldness. From now on, I will write her letters. If a few lines of my ink can bring Boles to life for her and make her burden lighter, it is the least I can do for a fellow human creature.

CHARACTER SKETCH

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"The narrator in Gorky’s story begins as a detached observer and ends as a compassionate participant. Prepare a character sketch of the student, highlighting his initial prejudices, his intellectual arrogance, and his eventual moral transformation."

(Hints:- educated yet narrow-minded – initial physical repulsion – intellectual arrogance and social distance – cynical reaction to Teresa’s "lies" – the turning point of empathy – internal conflict and shame – the "blockhead" realization – transition from observer to helper – newfound respect for the "human creature" – a witness to social tragedy)

THE STUDENT

The student is a complex character who represents the "educated" class of Moscow. Initially, he is prejudiced and shallow, focusing on Teresa’s unappealing physical traits and "muscular vigour." He uses his status as a student to justify his social detachment, keeping his door locked out of fear and disgust.However, he is not a static character. His intellectual arrogance is shattered when he discovers the tragic reason behind Teresa's imaginary lover. This epiphany forces him to confront his own lack of compassion. By calling himself a "blockhead," he acknowledges that true intelligence involves understanding human suffering. His character arc completes as he moves from a person who mocks Teresa to a person who actively helps her maintain her dignity through his writing, eventually becoming a sympathetic witness to her tragic life.

LETTER

Imagine you are 'Mr. Student.' A few months after Teresa was taken to prison, you are sitting in your room and you see the socks she mended for you. Write a letter to your friend in another city describing your encounter with Teresa and how she changed your perspective on life.

Moscow,

October 18, 1888

Dear Ivan,

I hope this letter finds you well in St. Petersburg. My studies here are progressing, but tonight my mind is far from my textbooks. I am sitting in my small room, looking at a pair of mended socks on my desk, and feeling a weight of shame that I cannot easily describe.

For months, I lived next to a woman named Teresa. To be honest, Ivan, I treated her with nothing but "horror" and disgust. She had a coarse face and a deep, masculine bass voice that repulsed me. Because I am a "Student," I looked down on her as a sub-human creature—someone far beneath my intellect and social standing.

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One day, she asked me to write a letter to her lover, Boles. I mocked her, thinking her stories were a "pack of lies." But then, I discovered the tragic truth: Boles did not exist. This lonely woman had invented a lover just to feel a spark of affection in a world that treated her with total indifference.

I realized then that I was the "blockhead," not her. My education had made me clever, but it had also made me heartless. I began writing her letters twice a week, and in return, she mended my clothes with a quiet, motherly care. We found a strange, beautiful friendship in that small gap between our rooms.

Teresa was taken to prison recently "for some reason or the other," and I fear she may never return. She has vanished, forgotten by everyone but me. She taught me that behind the coarsest exterior lies a "human creature" starving for kindness. I have learned that the greatest tragedy is not being poor, but being invisible to those who live "not three yards away."

Write back when you can. I find the silence of the hallway much louder now that she is gone.

Yours lovingly,

Mr. Student